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THE HINDU

Chef Vijay Kumar's journey from Natham to ringing the Nasdaq bell in New York **P2**

INVESTIGATING
PRITAM AND PEDRO **P4**



Dunk it in (Clockwise from right) A Karnataka-style dosa in the making; podi idlis with sambar and chutney; a cup of filter coffee; and customers at SIHI. **SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT**



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This article will roughly take you five minutes to read. It is, incidentally, the same span of time that a glossy ‘dose’ stuffed with red chilli paste and potato masal, then topped with a dollop of benne, takes to arrive on a plate.

If you have been a Chennai resident for long enough, you might have noticed a sudden but welcome rise in the number of Bengaluru-style darshinis (hotels by the roadside that use the quick-service model) to serve food that originates in Karnataka. On the menu, one can find the likes of the Bengaluru masala dose, Mysore masala dose, thatte idli, pongal, sabakki (sago)-based snacks and khara bath.

Priced at affordable rates, these restaurants now boast swanky interiors, and dedicated social media teams hyping up what one might have once dismissed as ‘ordinary’. Here, the art of dosa making has been chalked down to the second. Owners optimise time, manpower use, and sourcing – even deciding the number of times a ladle needs to be spun – to ensure that each fresh dosa arrives on a customer’s plate within minutes. Most importantly, everyone’s focus is on the sambar war, ensuring that the divide between Karnataka’s sweet sambar and Tamil Nadu’s more savoury version does not cause a loss in business.

Anish Akkalaneni, co-founder, Upavihar, a chain of six restaurants that started back in 2023, says that he remembers visiting Udupis, which serve Karnataka-style



food, before the advent of the Saravana Bhavans and Adyar Anandha Bhavans in Chennai. A regular at Sukh Sagar, and Doveton Cafe, he says, “I think the sambar played a major role in the shift from Udupis to Tamil-style restaurants. We preferred a spicier version,” he says. With the drop in popularity of the Udupis, the opportunity to sample Karnataka cuisine became few and far between. People had to travel to Bengaluru to eat a ‘dip’ – a bowl of idli or vade drowning in Karnataka-style sweet sambar and their coconut mint chutney.

Aashruth Rangarajan, founder, Eating Circles, which was one of the first restaurants in the city to enter the darshini lifestyle in 2016, followed this route. When he began working, he would travel to Bengaluru just for their breakfast. Every morning, he would be up, sampling the fare at crowded restaurants like MTR, CTR, and Vidyarthi Bhavan and wonder why food like this was unavailable in Chennai. He finally launched Eating Circles as a small kiosk-esque space in Kilpauk before moving to their larger location in Alwarpet. Suddenly,



Benne there, done that

Want a Mysore masala ‘dose’ or khara bath? Chennai residents are steadily indulging in the Bengaluru-style darshini experience. We find out what happens behind the scenes

there was an audience travelling from across the city to grab a plate of their Mangalore buns and rose milk. “In the initial days, not many people were used to the ticketed style of waiting for food. Then, we optimised,” he says.

From the motherland

It was only after COVID that a number of restaurants serving this style of food began rising though. “People were suddenly open to trying many new kinds of food here. It is perhaps what led to the success of our restaurant too,” says Upavihar’s Anish. The restaurateurs also

credit ghee-laden dishes at Rameshwaram Cafe going viral on social media to the rise in interest in Bengaluru-style food, but say that they would rather have their customers finish their whole plate, rather than waste because of the richness. Most say that they opted to follow the ‘OGs’ and the ‘Taaza Thindi model’ – a modern quick service restaurant in Bengaluru where food is also Instagrammable.

The attempt has always been mooted in the direction of authenticity. All the restaurateurs we met for this story say that they brought masters from Bengaluru and

Udupi to train their staff for over six months.

Anitha Sivakumar, founder, Sashwatha Cafe, who grew up in Dharmapuri, says that she would visit Bengaluru during every holiday season.

“In Karnataka, the dose, unlike the ones made at home, were sometimes more elaborate. We did research and development for a year, procuring much of our raw materials and coffee from Karnataka,

particularly Udupi, and then training our staff by convincing masters who were extremely hesitant to come to Chennai,” she says. After their first location in Nandanam, they have opened their second branch in Anna Nagar, where they are moving away from a token system and have focussed on table service instead.

Some of the challenges were unexpected. Childhood friends and business partners Rahul RH and Ajayraj KT behind SIHI (South Indian Heritage Inn) say that they searched high and low for dill leaves or sabakki soppu, instrumental for bringing the real taste of Bengaluru to our plates. “When I found that one dealer, you should have seen the joy on my face,” Rahul says. The two who grew up on a staple diet of thindi from ‘old Bangalore’ say that much of the food served under the guise of Karnataka cuisine is not real. “The Mysore masala for instance, does not have a green chutney as opposed to the red chutney in the Bangalore masala. It is served with sagu, a vegetable curry instead,” Rahul adds.

Anish from Upavihar says that they are the only ones in the city serving chirote, a sweet, golden brown poori of sorts, in the city. “At our fine-dining restaurants in ECR and Egmore, we also serve dishes that are Bengaluru imports like the butta cigar or the burashi kebab. The aim is to understand the cuisine at its depth and do the best possible version of it,” he says.

On the other hand, Raja Elumalai and Muthu Kumaran, who began Coffee and Tiffin Shastra, have customised the Bengaluru-style meal to offer food that is sensitive to the Chennai palette. “We are a

Chennai-person’s standard of Bengaluru food,” Raja says, adding that for instance, their bissebele bath comes with a hint of spice rather than sweetness from the sambar.

Going beyond

Restaurant operations like these have all been optimised so they can easily scale up. Anish from Upavihar says that their weekday Kitchen Order Ticket (KOTs) (where multiple people place one order) stands anywhere between 300-400 a day, while it rises to around 900 on the weekends for each branch; while it is around 500 KOTs on weekdays and around 1,000 for Tiffin Shastra. SIHI, which only began a month ago, is already pulling regulars who come in once a day all days of the week. Upavihar, which has six locations in the city, is looking to expand by at least three more by the end of the year. Sashwatha Cafe is opting for the franchise model, and moving to Sri Lanka and Hyderabad soon.

Parthibhan Kesavaraj, managing director, Nithya Amirtham Indian Food says that they opened Thuritham, their darshini-style vertical in 2025 with one restaurant in Adyar. They have five on-going projects, and five others in the pipeline by the end of the year. Evidently, expansion is the name of the game. Anitha from Sashwatha, Anish from Upavihar, Aashruth from Eating Circles, and Ajay from Sihi, all say that manpower and margins are their main challenges. “Acoffee cannot be above ₹40 and a dosa cannot be over ₹100. Margins are mostly at 10% for us but we make up because of our sheer volume,” Anish says.

Aashruth and Anish have been incentivising employees to stay with the brand by recognising their efforts. In addition, there are set instructions on the exact amount of ingredients to make batters, coffee, and even the number of turns that a dosa ladle must make for the perfect crisp exterior and soft interior. Rahul from Sihi says that they will soon have monitors in the kitchen that live track orders.

“What is the draw of this kind of darshini-style food?” Anish asks. I tell him that most items are familiar, clean, and easy to understand. There is something new for everyone to try and a lot to learn from a single breakfast outing.

“All that can be true. But taste. That is everything,” he responds. “Darshinis are tasty and people know what it is like to eat healthy, good tasting food, year-round.”



People are suddenly open to trying many new kinds of food in Chennai

ANISH AKKALANENI
Co-founder, Upavihar



Indian quilt art goes global

Birds of Paradise: A Symphony of Textile Art is an international collection of 101 contemporary art quilts, curated by Quilt India Foundation, celebrating artistic excellence through the medium of textile art.

Created by artists from India and around the world, this non-profit organisation is dedicated to promoting quilting as a contemporary textile art. The collection will embark on an international tour to places like South Africa and France for the South African International Quilt Festival, a significant international recognition of art quilts from India.



Taking on slow fashion

Kalpadruma, the lifestyle store, has partnered with handcrafted textile label The Svasa Collective for a five-day pop-up exhibition celebrating India’s textile heritage.

The exhibition showcases a curated collection of handcrafted sarees and blouses from weaving communities across the country. The collection includes kala cotton of Kutch, ponduru khadi, kalamkari of Andhra Pradesh, and bandhani from Gujarat and Rajasthan.

@Kalpadruma, Gopalapuram; July 3-7; 10am to 8pm. The exhibition is open to all. For details, call 9080402157.



The jazz conversation

The Louis Banks Trio returns to Chennai with One Night, One Legend, an intimate evening of jazz at Trinita Bar, The Residency Towers, on July 4 at 7.30pm. Led by the Grammy-nominated pianist and composer Louis Banks, the performance also features drummer Gino Banks and bassist Sheldon D’Silva. The evening offers a window into more than six decades of Indian jazz history, brought to life through the chemistry and improvisation of three musicians who have spent years performing together. Entry is priced at ₹1,000 per person. For reservations call 9344912033.



Regimental recipes

Inspired by old-world mess dining and summer kitchen traditions, Ministry of Chutneys at Radisson Blu Hotel & Suites GRT Chennai hosts a limited-period culinary showcase, Regimental Mess & Summer Kitchens. Until July 16, diners can enjoy dishes like aloo posto, badami shorba, and basanti pulao from the Calcutta Regiment, and from July 17 to 31, food, stories and nostalgia from the Punjab Regiment will be on offer. Dinner is priced at ₹2,549 exclusive of taxes on weekdays, while brunch starts at ₹2,950 exclusive of taxes on weekends. For reservations, call 8062210120.

In this exclusive essay for *The Hindu*, Vijay Kumar, the chef behind New York’s Michelin-starred Semma, reflects on his journey from a village near Natham in Tamil Nadu to global recognition, and what ringing the Nasdaq closing bell meant to him and the future of Tamil cuisine

Vijay Kumar

I rang the closing bell at Nasdaq, an American Stock Exchange in New York on May 1. This was as part of an event by Gold House, an organisation in the US that selects the Gold100: a group of 100 leaders responsible for shaping global culture over the past year. It was one of those moments when you look back and think, “How did I get here?” I’ve been having a lot of those moments lately. The James Beard Awards, Michelin, North America’s 50 Best Restaurants – each recognition has been incredibly meaningful, but has also given me an opportunity to pause and reflect on my journey. I did not have a ‘grand plan’ when I started cooking. If you had told me as a child growing up in Tamil Nadu that one day I would be standing in Times Square, recognised as a representative of South Indian food, I would never have believed you. I grew up in Samudirapatti near Natham, in Tamil Nadu’s Dindigul district, a 45-minute drive from Madurai city, where food was simply part of everyday life. Nobody talked about regional cuisine or culinary heritage. It was just what we ate – the fish curries my grandmother made, tamarind-foward meen kuzhambu, vegetables like drumstick, brinjal, snake gourd, cluster beans, ridge gourd and more. Aviyal, poriyal, kootu and vatha kuzhambu were made with vegetables that came from our farm. And I especially loved mullaikattiya thaniyam, a curd rice kanji often eaten with thuvaiyal that appeared during festivals, weddings, and family gatherings. Back then, I never imagined that those foods would become the foundation of my career, or that they would help reshape how

people think about Indian food in America. For years, I worked in kitchens where I was proud to cook Indian food, but I rarely saw the dishes I grew up eating represented on menus. Tamil cuisine is incredibly diverse, yet outside of South India, many people had never encountered it. I remember conversations before we opened Semma when



Long way from home



Bells and stars (Clockwise from left) Chef Vijay Kumar; Semma in New York City; Chef Vijay Kumar on the Nasdaq tower; nathai pirattal at Semma. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

people questioned whether dishes like nathai pirattal, our snail dish, belonged on a restaurant menu in New York. To me, that dish represented exactly why Semma needed to exist. Snails were part of the food culture where I grew up, they were not exotic or provocative, they were simply food. The same could be said of many dishes on our menu and I believed that if we cooked these dishes honestly, people would connect with them. Thankfully, they did. When you’re in the restaurant every day, it can be difficult to step back and recognise the impact of the work you’re doing. You focus on the next service, the next prep list, and the next challenge.



Moments like ringing the closing bell force you to look up for a second and realise that people are paying attention, they are connected. Tamil food has reached places I never imagined it would. What has surprised me most is the impact this journey has had on my family. My mother still asks the same questions she always has. “Have you eaten? Are you sleeping enough?” Some things never change. But I know she follows everything from the same home she has lived in for decades. Whenever there is an article or an award, the news often reaches her before I have a chance to tell her myself. One of the benefits of growing up in a small village. I remember speaking to my family after some of the recognition Semma received, after it launched in October 2021. Today, at Semma the waitlist is approximately 1,200 people, with 200 covers a night. Of course my family is happy for me, but what makes them happiest is seeing people appreciate our food. These are dishes we have cooked, shared, and celebrated

our entire lives, and knowing that people halfway around the world value those traditions means more to me than any award ever could. As for what’s next, Semma is only the beginning. Tamil Nadu has an endless number of dishes, ingredients, and techniques that deserve attention such as pirandai, a herb that is worked into a chutney and mocha, which is close to edamame. As we continue to evolve the menu, I find myself looking deeper rather than wider. There are recipes from villages and communities across the State that rarely leave their place of origin. There are dishes like fish kuzhambu, offal preparations, regional vatha kuzhambu, millet-based dishes, that I grew up eating that I have never seen represented outside Tamil Nadu. These are the dishes that are disappearing, they carry the identity of specific villages and communities. Those are the stories that interest me most. No matter how things evolve, my goal will always be the same: to cook honestly, respect where the food comes from, and tell the story as accurately as possible. Everything else is a bonus. When I stood at Nasdaq that day, I wasn’t thinking about awards or accolades. I was thinking about the journey. I was thinking about my family, my teachers, and all the people who shaped me along the way. Most of all, I was thinking about how far a simple plate of food can travel.

Chef Vijay Kumar is executive chef and partner at New York’s Michelin-starred Semma. He won the 2025 James Beard Award for Best Chef: New York State and has become one of the world’s leading champions of regional Tamil cuisine. (Order the gunpowder dosa and snail pirattal if you manage to snag a reservation)



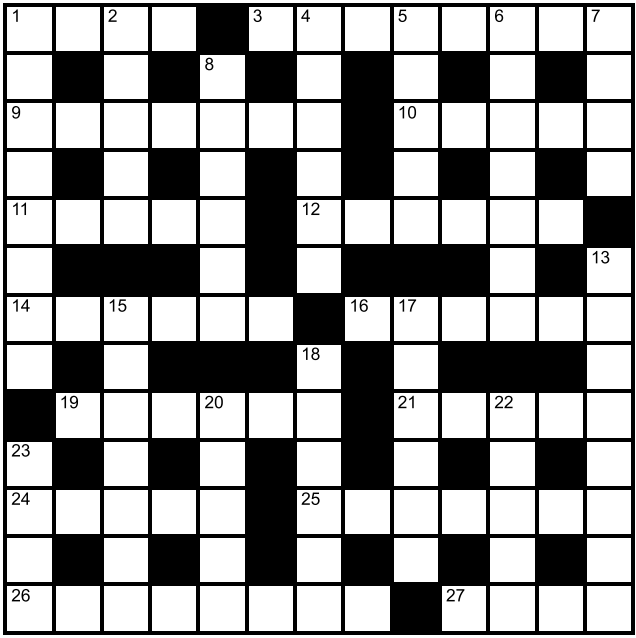
Stories in leather Hidesign has unveiled its redesigned 600 sq ft store on the second floor of Express Avenue mall, bringing the brand’s story-led approach forward. The space features leather-clad façades, antique furniture, and seed-based artworks. Alongside collections like The Icons, East India, and Atelier, shoppers can explore the latest Maison Seine and On the Road collections.



Cuppa joe (Left) Coffee fruit on the vines; (below) Yettu coffee at a convention in Japan and its founder Vignesh; (inset) Yettu coffee. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #60 (Set by Doppelganger)



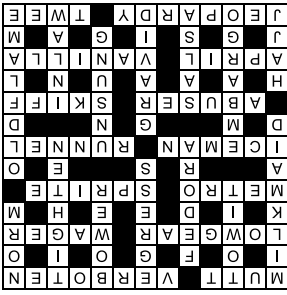
- Across
- 1 Mongrel (4)
 - 3 Prohibited (8)
 - 9 State of minimum activity (3,4)
 - 10 Bet (5)
 - 11 Subway system (5)
 - 12 Elf (6)
 - 14 Professional killer (6)
 - 16 Rivulet (6)
 - 19 Misuser (6)
 - 21 Flatbottom boat (5)
 - 24 Month (5)
 - 25 Flavouring extract (7)
 - 26 Peril (8)
 - 27 Overly precious (4)
- Down
- 1 Dairy worker (8)
 - 2 Namely (2,3)
 - 4 Emergence (6)
 - 5 Leafy recess (5)
 - 6 Constrict (7)
 - 7 Standard (4)
 - 8 Hat (6)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 13 Former lover (3,5)
- 15 Ban (7)
- 17 Not honoured (6)
- 18 Carrying eggs (6)
- 20 Spicy sauce (5)
- 22 Relative by marriage (2-3)
- 23 Muslim pilgrimage (4)

Solution No. 60



Sanjana Ganesh

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Twelve years ago, V Vignesh was just another coffee obsessive trying to get a decent cup in a city best known for filter coffee. Today he has co-founded Yettu, the Chennai brand behind what is being billed as a specialty craft coffee that comes together in under a minute – no fancy espresso machine, no aeropress, just hot water and a bottle. You might think that instant coffee just got a better rep. But, sit with Vignesh for 10 minutes, and he will talk you out of that notion entirely. “People talk a lot about instant noodles, but in Japan everyone has instant noodles. It doesn’t mean it’s of a lower quality. They have just made it accessible,” he says. “We are calling it craft coffee because the craft happens from the farm. People have to pick the coffee a certain way, process it a certain way. There is craft at every single step,” he says. Yettu works with around 30 and

Instant gratification

Coffee connoisseurs will bet on their life that a cup of instant coffee tastes burnt, even putrid. Yettu, a craft coffee that can be brewed in seconds, attempts to challenge this notion

50 farms across the country – in Nagaland, a village called Thizama near Kohima, Koraput in Odisha, Valparai and Yercaud in Tamil Nadu, and a Robusta belt outside Coorg. Not all of them make the final cut, but Vignesh describes it less as sourcing and more as a shared project. “There are a lot of farmers who want to be part of this journey,” he says. “We are their partners – from when it starts to when it ends.” A special heirloom Arabica coffee which is the only one of its kind, was picked up by a Japanese roaster, processed using techniques the team brought back from their trips to Tokyo. Look East Japan, in fact, is where this story really begins. Vignesh, who calls the

country the Mecca of coffee, is astounded that a tea-drinking country has built an entire culture around drip brewing almost out of obsession. “We wanted our Indian coffee to be known there,” he says. “That was the whole idea of going to Japan.” This, of course, has not happened overnight. An early batch sent over did not particularly excel. Yettu went back, set up at the Specialty Coffee Association of Japan trade show in Tokyo, and spent months in 2025 running cupping sessions with roasters across the country. At one popular coffee festival, the brand sold around 600 cups over a day and a half. “Today, our coffee is a staple for close to a hundred of Japan’s top roasters,” he adds. Closer home, the Chennai pop-ups and their five stealth launches till date,

have drawn their own following for Yettu, including some uses that Vignesh did not see coming. “Someone made a protein bowl with only this coffee,” he says. “Someone made a banana bread latte with it. There’s a baker in Bengaluru [Maki] who’s made a whole line of desserts with it,” he says. Part of the appeal is shelf life. Because the coffee is fresh-roasted, fresh-brewed and bottled before it ever reaches a customer, Vignesh says a jar that can make 10 cups, holds its quality long after opening. The oldest batch they have tested has crossed nine months. Even Yettu’s name carries layers of meaning for Vignesh, drawing on infinity, coffee beans, a petroglyph excavated in Goa, and temple architecture. He says, “We wanted India to look as cool as it is.” A jar of Yettu Coffee is priced at ₹360 during the current launch period and can be delivered within the city. To place your order, log onto yettu.in

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Katharina Görgen arrived in Chennai in August 2020 at the height of the COVID-19 pandemic, to take over as director of Goethe-Institut Chennai. “For almost two years, no one even knew that Goethe-Institut had a new director, as we had suspended all events and even our German language classes were offered online,” says Katharina. Now, as her six-year tenure comes to an end, and she prepares to start work at Goethe-Institut in Kraków, Poland, Leonhard Emmerling will take over as director of Goethe-Institut Chennai. An art historian, curator and author, Leonhard previously served as director, Programmes for South Asia at Goethe-Institut/Max Mueller Bhavan in New Delhi and has led Goethe-Institut centres in Chicago and Houston. His plan for the years ahead involve building on the institute’s legacy while forging new conversations with Chennai’s cultural community.

Sparking a feminist discourse Katharina’s tenure has been marked by a strong commitment to feminist discourse and practice. She conceptualised and supported several flagship projects, including exhibitions, residencies and interdisciplinary programmes. “I am particularly proud of having built a strong network during my tenure, especially with the Chennai Photo Biennale, DakshinaChitra, Tara Books, Alliance Française and SNS Consultancy. I also enjoyed putting together The Little Lit Festival, the International Children’s Literature Festival 2.0 (2025),” she says. She adds that her biggest challenge was finding common ground. “The concept of public art is yet to be firmly established here, but there is immense scope for exploration. Public spaces are



Listening before leading

As Katharina Görgen leaves for her next posting in Kraków, incoming director Leonhard Emmerling, an art historian and curator, outlines his plans for cultural exchange



A new beginning (Clockwise from left) Incoming director, Goethe-Institut Chennai, Leonhard Emmerling; outgoing director Katharina Görgen; the Children’s Literature Festival 2.0. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, RAGU R AND AKHILA EASWARAN

ideal for art to reach a wider audience. People may hesitate to enter an art gallery or even Goethe-Institut, but they may have no such inhibitions about engaging with art in public spaces,” she states. The Goethe-Institut has seen an significant increase in enrolment for in-person classes in recent months. “After the pandemic, most people preferred online classes. However, I think many now choose to step out of their homes and attend classes in person, as it provides an opportunity to meet and interact with like-minded people,” she says, adding that she also facilitated a sign language course.

Going local Inspired by her interest in movement and fitness, Katharina learnt silambam, the traditional Tamil martial art, training twice a week with master Silambarasan while she lived in Chennai. “My predecessor, Helmut Schippert, used to cycle everywhere when he was here. I explored the city on foot and would simply walk to all the places I intended to visit,” says Katharina. “In recent

times, I have especially enjoyed walking along Khader Nawaz Khan Road, which has undergone a complete transformation.”

The road ahead Rather than arriving with a fixed agenda, Leonhard says his first priority is to listen. “Everything we do at the Goethe-Institut should be based on the idea of dialogue and exchange,” he says, adding that he wants future programmes to emerge organically through conversations with artists, writers, museums and cultural institutions in the city, rather than from preconceived ideas. The final phase of The Female Legacy Project, a multi-media initiative, will be completed under his leadership.

Having previously served as Director of Programmes for South Asia at Goethe-Institut/Max Mueller Bhavan in New Delhi, Leonhard says he is looking forward to reconnecting with the region through Chennai’s vibrant cultural landscape. He sees the city’s museums, music venues and dance institutions as spaces where conversations around history, aesthetics and the role of art in contemporary society can flourish.

An art historian and curator by training, Leonhard believes museums are far more than repositories of the past. Instead, he sees them as spaces that help societies understand the present by engaging critically with history. The same philosophy informs his understanding of cultural diplomacy, which he describes as an exchange of ideas and values that enriches both sides.

For his first year in Chennai, Leonhard is not looking to introduce sweeping changes. Instead, he hopes to build relationships based on trust, curiosity and mutual respect. His aim, he says, is for Goethe-Institut Chennai to be recognised as an institution that listens first and develops programmes through shared interests, allowing meaningful and unexpected collaborations to take shape.



Creative haven

Some spaces become more than venues. Over time, they evolve into testing grounds where musicians perform unfinished songs, comedians try out fresh material, poets read new work aloud, and strangers become collaborators. Over the last eight years, House of T has quietly grown into one such space in Chennai, earning a reputation as a platform where artistes are encouraged to experiment rather than perfect.

“We’ve always believed that artistes need spaces where they can simply try things out. Whether it’s someone performing for the first time or an established musician testing new material, House of T has always been about creating that safe space. Every event in this anniversary celebration connects back to that journey. Our roots, the people we’ve grown with, and the community we’ve built over eight years are all coming together,” says Thomas Davis, founder and curator, House of T.

That journey now finds expression in a four-day anniversary celebration at Vinyl & Brew in Alwarpet. Instead of a single commemorative event, House of T has curated four distinct experiences that reflect the different communities it has nurtured over the years.

The celebrations begin on July 16 with *Retrograde*, a listening session led by musician Sai Sanjith that encourages audiences to engage deeply with music. On July 17, the focus shifts to Chennai’s independent music scene with an acoustic evening featuring bands Seattle Wildfire and Mr Ago and the Plastic People. July 18 brings the anniversary edition of House of T’s Open Mic, where musicians, comics, poets and storytellers will share original material. The celebrations conclude on July 19 with a pop-up market featuring independent artistes, makers, creative entrepreneurs and a curated vinyl listening session.

@Vinyl & Brew, Alwarpet from July 16 to 19. For tickets and performance passes log on @houseoftofficial on Instagram.



Nature reimagined

Through The Magnificent Life, artist Rajesh RV imagines a world of harmony and hope



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As a child, artist Rajesh RV was drawn to the natural world, spending hours watching National Geographic, BBC Earth, and wildlife documentaries. “Around the V or VI standard, I started watching these programmes with my father,” he recalls. That lifelong fascination with wildlife and Nature has now found expression in his ongoing exhibition, The Magnificent Life, at Forum Art Gallery. A sense of mysticism permeates Rajesh’s canvases, where animals take centre stage. Interwoven with elements of the earth, the cosmos and the universe, the work reflects his vision of an alternate reality, where there is a harmonious coexistence bound by mutual respect rather than dominance. Rajesh’s works challenge conventional ideas of artistic

Salt of the earth Advaita-I by Rajesh RV. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mediums. Instead of relying on acrylic or watercolours, his compositions are built on mixed media, weaving together pieces from newspapers, books, and magazines. “Each element reflects the work of many people. Their environments, clothing, colours, and choices all become part of the narrative,” says Rajesh. The artist structures each canvas around a three-part grid, with each section representing a different aspect of Nature and the universe. The colour palette is a treat to the eyes, each canvas, a world on its own. While most humans are depicted in black, the background moves to vibrant colours. “The visual tension is designed to compel viewers to stop, stand, and examine how these colours interact,” says Rajesh.

The Magnificent Life is on at the Forum Art Gallery, Padmanabha Nagar, Adyar, till August 8, from 10.30am to 6pm (except Sundays). Entry is free.

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FARNAZ

Rise of the Titan

Journalist Vinay Kamath reflects on seeing his book on Titan's journey transformed into a hit web series



About time
Jim Sarbh in *Made in India: A Titan Story*. SPECIAL
ARRANGEMENT

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This is an idea whose time has come. And interestingly, the idea is about time itself. Three weeks into its streaming, *Made in India: A Titan Story* on Amazon MX Player is already 2026's most-viewed Indian web series, according to the latest Ormax report. Chronicling the journey of Titan founder Xerxes Desai and his mentor, JRD Tata, the biographical drama transports viewers to the early 1970s and 80s Bombay where the foundation of India's iconic watch brand was laid. Directed by Robbie Grewal and starring Jim Sarbh and Naseeruddin Shah, the series has been hailed as a tale of ambition and nation-building. This web series has a Chennai connection; it is based on city journalist Vinay Kamath's book *Titan: Inside India's Most Successful Consumer Brand*, published by Hachette India. A former *The Hindu Business Line* journalist, Vinay is pleased with the response to the series that has brought to screen the events he chronicled over years of reporting. "I am overwhelmed with the outpouring of emotions for it," he says. "The story of innovation and surpassing odds, the period setting, interspersed with old Hindi songs, has gone down well

with viewers." Vinay's book, released in December 2018, was the result of three years of work as the bulk of the interviewing and writing happened alongside his work as a journalist with *The Hindu Business Line*. According to him, the most compelling narrative of the Titan story was how it was founded against all odds. "Neither of the co-founders, Xerxes Desai and Anil Manchanda, was an engineer. Yet both of them had the gumption to enter a high-precision engineering industry, knowing they could hire talent. There were many twists and turns in the founding of the company; a large business group like the Tatas could not enter watchmaking as it was reserved for the public sector and small-scale sector because of the archaic MRTCP Act restrictions. Titan's founding was also helped by a TN cadre IAS officer, Iravatham Mahadevan, also a renowned epigraphist. So, several serendipitous events came together in Titan's founding," states Vinay. Based on real events, *Made In India: A Titan Story* might pave the way for more business and feel-good stories on streaming platforms. "It is quite different from what is usually on offer, and it is this uniqueness that has made the series an audience favourite," adds Vinay.



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Rajkumar Hirani brings his trademark comic punches and light-hearted storytelling to OTT with his streaming debut, the upcoming JioHotstar show *Pritam and Pedro*. Inspired by the books *Hidden Files* (published by Unbound Script) and *Return of the Trojan Horse* (published by Leadstart Publishing) by Amit Dubey, the series tells a story centred around cybercrime featuring an unlikely bond between an angry cop, played by Arshad Warsi, and a hacker, played by Vir Hirani. Rajkumar, who serves as the creator, producer and co-writer, says he discovered these books and was fascinated by how cybercrime takes place and how it gets solved. While working on the episodic series, the filmmaker realised that the writing process had to be different from a feature film. "Working on a film involves compressing your writing. You can't really open it up and focus on individual personal journeys of characters. All of that is possible while doing a show. It also requires you to build a lot of tension points, either in the middle of episodes or at the end, which

The magic of writing

Creator, producer and co-writer Rajkumar Hirani, actor Arshad Warsi and director Avinash Arun discuss their show, *Pritam and Pedro*

we don't need as much in a feature film," says Rajkumar. Interestingly, the show is directed by Avinash Arun, known for helming gritty crime thrillers like *Paatal Lok* season 2 and *School of Lies*. The tone in *Pritam and Pedro* marks a shift for him, but Avinash says that he doesn't look at stories through the lens of genre. "What excites me is the kind of relationship that a script builds with me," he says while invoking the genius of AR Rahman to make his point. "He can make a qawwali, a Bhakti song, a classical song or even an African song. He does it all. So, I feel it is important to have that kind of empathy as an artiste where you can work with any form; to be like water and just flow," Avinash says. The same can be said for Arshad's comic timing, which flows even in the most unusual moments, hitting the right notes and elevating the

stature of seemingly ordinary scenes. His improvisations in the *Munna Bhai* films have aptly become meme templates along with his quirky reactions in the *Dhamaal* and *Golmaal* series. The actor says that comedy comes instinctively for him. Rajkumar adds that Arshad finds humour in every situation. "Never take him to a funeral," he jokes. Arshad is suddenly reminded of another anecdote. "I did this at a funeral. My wife was saying to someone, 'I am so sorry for your loss'. Again, words just came out of me, and I said, 'Don't feel sorry, it's not your fault'," says Arshad, sending the three on a bout of laughter again. But there is also a technique to his comedy. "I give odd pauses in between dialogues sometimes," says Arshad. "You can elongate the pause or shorten it, and

Over the years, one discovers some things, but the magic of writing is that there is no fixed rule or grammar to it

RAJKUMAR HIRANI
Creator, producer, co-writer



the punch lands differently." Even for Rajkumar, writing comedy is mostly following his instincts. "I wish there was a particular pathway to it, but there isn't. If you're writing something and it makes you laugh, you think it's working. Over the years, one discovers some things, but the magic of writing is that there is no fixed rule or grammar to it," he says, while acknowledging the subjectivity around comedy. "What you find funny, someone else may not. Or it also happens that it could collapse on the way. A film is like a train; you start with the script. But if the timing between the actors is not good, it starts derailing. By the end, it can become something else altogether. So, one has to just hope that what works for you will also work for others," says Rajkumar. Apart from writing and directing his films, Rajkumar has also been editing his own work. Even on *Pritam and Pedro*, he serves as the editor. He calls editing "another form of writing." "The script is written, it is then shot, and it may get translated into visuals or not. Then the editor has to have an understanding of the script to know what it was trying to do. If it's not succeeding in doing that, the editor has to step in. The entire meaning can change by deciding where to pause, when to cutaway, what to show to the audience and what not to show to build suspense. It's like a jigsaw puzzle and something completely magical," Rajkumar says. Being someone who is part of a film right from the writing stage to the editing stage, how does Rajkumar remain objective about his work? "I have tried getting somebody else for the edit. They always say that it's better to have an objective mind. But I feel the subjective mind needs to make sense of everything. Because getting a new person to understand what you want takes a lot of time. I just cannot work with another editor. I need to edit my own films," concludes Rajkumar.

Building tension
A still from *Balan*; (inset) director Chidambaram. ROHITH K SURESH AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Hattrick of hits

As *Balan* continues to reign at the box office, director Chidambaram talks about what went into the making of the slow-burn thriller

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Mention the hattrick of hits and Chidambaram acknowledges with a smile. As his new film, *Balan: The Boy*, continues to draw people to theatres and garner pan-Indian recognition, the director looks at it differently. "We feel lucky to be discussed at a time when there is so much content to consume. This level of appreciation was not

expected. The fact that it has communicated with the people the way we intended has brought immense satisfaction," says the filmmaker. He has proven with *Balan* his belief that the strength of Malayalam cinema lies in its "stories, the drama and performances". Written by Jithu Madhavan, the director of two huge hits in Malayalam – *Romancham* and *Aavesham* – the film is about a mother (Farzana Palathingal), a murder

convict, and her young son (Adisheshan KR), both of whom are shown as living in the prison when the movie begins. Once they step out of jail, it becomes a story of their survival. After a memorable debut with *Jan.E.Man* and a blockbuster second movie, *Manjummel Boys*, Chidambaram was getting ready to step into Hindi cinema with a big project. It was while waiting for that film to take off

that he chanced upon Jithu's story. "What struck me the most was the setting. Even though Jithu was busy with his next project [in Tamil with Suriya], he sat down with me to work on the screenplay. We held several discussions, analysing every aspect of the plot. Shyju ikka [cinematographer Shyju Khalid] would also join us often. The foundation of the film is Jithu's story – he had traced the boy's journey so well leading towards the climax. I added a few scenes, which were needed for the flow of the story. Basically we sat down to find a common voice and ended up having around a dozen drafts before locking the final script." But, the film was not without its challenges. "Since it is my third film, I believe I have some hold over the craft. But, even though the story of *Balan* looks simple, it was important to extract the right amount of emotion from the characters. The film had to be emotional, entertaining and engaging. If there was just melodrama the film would have never worked," he says. Chidambaram adds that he allowed the narrative to take its time. "That pace was needed to build the tension towards the interval. I wanted the audience to empathise with the mother and son and for that I chose to unravel the layers one by one." Before the movie went on the floors, he had interacted with police officers at various women's prisons in Kerala. "Even though there aren't many scenes of the mother in the jail,

it was important to understand the lives of women prisoners. That is why we met the police officers who interact with them on a daily basis. We saw in person the steps they take to avoid untoward incidents. Like, for instance, the top officer tastes the food served every day. Apparently there can be problems if the rice is not cooked properly or there is not enough salt in a dish!" Besides Shyju, *Balan*'s crew boasts the best hands in Indian cinema – Vivek Harshan (editor), Ajayan Challisserry (production designer), Sushin Shyam (composer) etc among others. "I was in good hands. Since we all are friends, communication was easy. All of them have done a lot of movies and it is that experience they brought to the table." Chidambaram states that working with child actors had its challenges. "It was important that they remain focussed. Also, it was not possible for them to shoot for long hours. Although he is very young, Adisheshan understood enough about his character and the techniques to make him give the right emotions worked." Earlier this year, Chidambaram made his acting debut in *Oru Durooha Sahacharyathil* directed by Ratheesh Balakrishna Poduval. "I was quite apprehensive how it would turn out. Thankfully I was in a comfortable space. Chackochan [Kunchacko Boban] helped a lot," he says. Is he open to do more roles? "If something good comes along I might take it up," he says.



NTR, Trivikram Srinivas reunite for a Telugu magnum opus
Telugu filmmaker Trivikram Srinivas has reunited with his *Aravinda Sametha Veera Raghava* star Jr NTR for an upcoming film. The ambitious Telugu film is jointly produced by S Radha Krishna of Haarika & Hassine Creations banner and Nandamuri Kalyan Ram on behalf of NTR Arts. Revolving around Lord Muruga, the film will be "rooted in divinity, with mythology-inspired storytelling, intense emotions, breathtaking action and spectacular world building," said the makers. Anirudh Ravichander is on board to compose the music of the film.



Suriya reunites with Jai Bhim director
Tamil star Suriya is all set to reunite with Jai Bhim director TJ Gnanavel for an upcoming film produced by Hombale Films. The untitled film marks Suriya's first collaboration with the production house behind blockbuster franchises such as *K.G.F.*, *Kantara*, and *Salaar*. The film, which was launched this week, features Kayadu Lohar as the female lead. The film boasts a strong technical crew, with Sai Abhyankkar composing the music, SR Kathir serving as cinematographer, and Philomin Raj editing the project.